

GIO AZZARELLO

The First Apartment Cookbook

*How to buy ingredients, cook real food, prep for the week,
and enjoy it enough to keep going.*

MASTER EDITION · VOLUMES 1-8

How to use this book

This isn't a stack of recipes to follow once. It's a system. **Part 1** sets up your kitchen, pantry, and habits — read it first. **Parts 2–8** are 74 recipes grouped by cuisine, each written the same way so they're easy to scan mid-cook. The **Reference** at the back holds your sauces, marinades, shopping lists, and the meal-prep formula. The goal is consistency, not perfection: cook at home most of the time and actually enjoy it, and you've won.

The rating system

Difficulty ●	1 dot = total beginner · 5 dots = advanced. Most weeknight food is 1–2.
Cost \$	1 = cheap · 4 = save it for a special night.
Meal Prep ■	How well it holds up cooked ahead and portioned. 5 = make a big batch Sunday.
Reheat ■	How good it is on day three. 5 = tastes the same or better.
Serves / Protein	Shown where it helps you plan portions and hit your protein.

Contents

PART 1	Foundations	3
PART 2	Mexican	7
PART 3	Italian	13
PART 4	Asian	17
PART 5	American Comfort	22
PART 6	High Protein & San Diego	28
PART 7	Bread & Baking	33
PART 8	Hosting & Special Occasion	36
REFERENCE	Sauces, Lists & Systems	39

PART 1

Foundations

Not recipes — the skills, pantry, and systems that make every recipe easier.

Your Kitchen Philosophy

You're not trying to become a chef. You're becoming someone who can feed himself, enjoys cooking, saves money, eats healthier, and can cook for friends and family. The goal isn't perfection — it's **consistency**. Cook at home 80% of the time and genuinely enjoy it, and you win.

Your Equipment & Heat Guide

TOOL	USE IT FOR
12" Tri-Ply Stainless Skillet	Steak, chicken, carne asada, eggs, vegetables, pan sauces, stir fry
Stainless Saucepan	Rice, pasta, sauces, oatmeal, soups
Dutch Oven	Chili, soups, stews, bread, pot roast, big pasta sauces
Air Fryer	Chicken thighs, vegetables, potatoes, reheating (375–400°F)
Blender	Shakes, salsas, sauces, marinades
KitchenAid Mixer	Bread, pizza dough, biscuits, brownies, cookies, cakes

Heat: Low = eggs, butter, sauces · Medium = most cooking · Medium-High = chicken, vegetables · High = searing steak only.

Food Safety — The One Rule

When in doubt, throw it out. A \$5 meal is cheaper than food poisoning.

INTERNAL TEMPERATURES

Chicken	165°F
Ground beef	160°F
Steak (medium rare)	130–135°F
Pork	145°F

Store leftovers within 2 hours. Eat within 3–5 days. Buy a \$12 instant-read thermometer — never guess.

Master Pantry — Always Keep These

Proteins

Eggs · chicken thighs · chicken breast · ground beef (90/10) · chuck roast · bacon · shredded mozzarella · parmesan · Greek yogurt

Grains & Dry

Jasmine rice · spaghetti · penne · flour · breadcrumbs · tortillas

Fruit & Fresh

Limes · lemons · bananas · apples · milk · butter · cheese

Vegetables

Yellow onions · garlic · carrots · celery · broccoli · Brussels sprouts · bell peppers · cilantro · green onions · potatoes

Canned

Crushed tomatoes · tomato paste · black, pinto & kidney beans · chicken broth · beef broth

Oils & Vinegars

Olive oil (finishing/medium) · avocado oil (high heat) · rice, white & apple cider vinegar

Spices — Buy in This Order

Tier 1 (these 8 make 80% of your meals): kosher salt, black pepper, garlic powder, onion powder, paprika, chili powder, cumin, Italian seasoning.

Tier 2: oregano, crushed red pepper, cinnamon, bay leaves, smoked paprika.

BLEND	MIX
Mexican	1 tsp each salt, cumin, chili powder, garlic powder + ½ tsp paprika
Italian	1 tsp each salt, pepper, garlic powder, Italian seasoning
BBQ	Salt, pepper, paprika, garlic powder, brown sugar
Asian	Soy sauce, garlic, ginger, rice vinegar, sesame oil

Knife Skills — Start Here

Grip: pinch the blade between thumb and forefinger — don't grip only the handle. The first five skills show up in hundreds of recipes: **dice an onion**, **slice an onion**, **mince garlic**, **chop cilantro**, **slice chicken**.

The Weekly Meal-Prep System

Every Sunday, cook one **protein**, one **vegetable**, one **carb** — for example chicken thighs, broccoli, rice. Portion into lunch, dinner, and an emergency meal for several days. Use the formula on the next pages to keep it from getting boring (400 combinations).

Reheating: Rice — add 1 tbsp water, cover, microwave. Chicken — reheat gently, don't overcook. Pizza — skillet, never the microwave.

Master Guides — Rice, Eggs, Chicken, Vegetables

Jasmine rice: 1 cup rice + 1½ cups water. Rinse → boil → cover → LOW 15 min → off heat, rest 10 min → fluff. *Batch:* 3 cups rice + 4.5 cups water = ~9 cups (4–5 days).

Eggs: Scrambled — 2 eggs + 1 tbsp butter, medium-low, stir constantly, pull just before done. Hard boiled — boil, add eggs, 10 min, ice bath, peel.

Chicken: Air-fryer thighs — 400°F, 18–22 min to 175°F. Pan-seared breast — medium, 6–8 min/side to 165°F, rest 5 min.

Broccoli / Brussels: 425°F. Broccoli 20–25 min; Brussels (halved) 25–30 min. Olive oil, salt, pepper, garlic powder.

Five Mistakes to Avoid

1. Overcrowding the pan — food steams instead of browning. **2. Not salting enough** — most beginner food is under-seasoned. **3. Cooking everything on high** — medium is your friend. **4. Not resting meat** — rest 5–10 min. **5. Buying too many gadgets** — master technique first.

Shopping — Where to Buy What

Costco

Chicken thighs · ground beef · chuck roast · pork shoulder · steaks on sale · frozen broccoli & mixed veg · eggs · cheese · Greek yogurt · butter · rice · olive & avocado oil · salt · pepper · paper towels

Trader Joe's

Fresh herbs · limes · lemons · garlic · onions · pizza dough · specialty cheeses · frozen appetizers · unique sauces

PART 2

Mexican

Top priority — San Diego food, the flavors you'll eat most.

1 Cilantro Lime Rice

One of the most-used recipes in the whole book. Pairs with carne asada, chicken bowls, burrito bowls, fajitas.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

SERVES 4–6

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup jasmine rice
- 1½ cups water
- 1 tbsp butter
- 1 tsp kosher salt
- Juice of 1 lime
- ¼ cup chopped cilantro

METHOD

1. Rinse rice in a strainer under cold water, stirring with your fingers, until the water runs mostly clear.
2. Add rice, water, butter, and salt to the saucepan.
3. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Don't walk away.
4. Once boiling, cover, drop heat to LOW, and cook 15 minutes — lid stays on the whole time.
5. Turn the heat off and let it rest, still covered, 10 minutes.
6. Add lime juice and cilantro, fluff with a fork, and serve.

Storage: Up to 5 days · **Reheat:** Add 1 tbsp water, cover, microwave 1–2 min

2 Pico de Gallo

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 4 Roma tomatoes
- ½ white onion
- ½ bunch cilantro
- 1 lime
- 1 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Dice the tomatoes and onion small. Chop the cilantro.
2. Combine in a bowl.
3. Add lime juice and salt, mix.
4. Rest 15 minutes, then taste and adjust salt.

3 Blender Salsa

The everyday salsa you'll make constantly.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 can fire-roasted tomatoes
- 1 garlic clove
- ½ white onion
- 1 jalapeño
- ½ bunch cilantro
- Juice of 1 lime
- 1 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Put everything in the blender.
2. Blend 10–15 seconds — do not overblend, you want texture.
3. Taste, add salt if needed, refrigerate.

4 Salsa Roja (Taco-Shop Style)

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 6 Roma tomatoes
- 2 jalapeños
- 2 garlic cloves
- ½ onion
- 1 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Roast tomatoes, jalapeños, garlic and onion under the broiler or in a dry skillet until charred.
2. Blend with salt until smooth.
3. Cool and serve.

5 Salsa Verde

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb tomatillos (husked)
- 2 jalapeños
- 1 garlic clove
- ½ onion
- Handful cilantro
- Salt to taste

METHOD

1. Roast tomatillos, jalapeños, garlic and onion until soft and blistered.
2. Blend with cilantro and salt.
3. Taste and adjust.

6 Guacamole

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 3 avocados
- 1 lime
- ¼ cup diced onion
- ¼ cup chopped cilantro
- 1 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Mash the avocados to the texture you like.
2. Add lime, onion, cilantro and salt.
3. Mix, taste, adjust salt.

7 Ground Beef Taco Meat

One of the highest-value recipes in the book — taco night, burrito bowls, nachos.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb ground beef
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- 1 tsp chili powder
- 1 tsp cumin
- ½ tsp paprika
- ¼ cup water

METHOD

1. Heat the skillet over medium.
2. Add beef and break it apart as it browns.
3. Drain excess grease if needed.
4. Add the spices and water; cook 3–4 minutes until saucy.
5. Serve.

Storage: 5 days · **Reheat:** Skillet or microwave

8 Chicken Fajita Bowls

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs chicken thighs
- 2 bell peppers, sliced
- 1 onion, sliced
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- 1 tsp chili powder
- 1 tsp cumin

METHOD

1. Slice peppers and onion; trim the chicken.
2. Toss everything together with oil and seasoning.
3. Spread on a sheet pan and roast at 425°F for 25 minutes, until chicken hits 175°F.
4. Build the bowl: rice, chicken, peppers, pico, guacamole.

9 Slow Cooker Salsa Chicken

One of the best set-and-forget meal-prep recipes there is.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs chicken breast
- 16 oz salsa
- 1 packet taco seasoning

METHOD

1. Put everything in the crockpot.
2. Cook LOW 6–8 hours or HIGH 3–4 hours.
3. Shred with two forks, stir back into the sauce, serve.

10 Authentic Carne Asada

The crown jewel. Learn this and you'll impress people.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs flank steak
- ½ cup orange juice
- Juice of 2 limes
- ¼ cup olive oil
- 4 garlic cloves
- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp chili powder
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp pepper

METHOD

1. Mix all marinade ingredients, add the steak, and marinate at least 4 hours (overnight is best).
2. Remove the steak and pat it completely dry — this is what lets it sear instead of steam.
3. Heat the skillet over medium-high with avocado oil.
4. Sear 4–6 minutes per side to an internal 130–135°F.
5. Rest 10 minutes. Do not skip this.
6. Slice thin AGAINST the grain and serve.

11 Breakfast Burritos

Meal-prep king. Make a batch, freeze, grab on the way out.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 8 eggs
- 1 lb breakfast sausage
- 1 cup shredded cheese
- 8 tortillas

METHOD

1. Cook the sausage, then remove.
2. Scramble the eggs.
3. Combine sausage, eggs and cheese.
4. Fill tortillas, roll, and wrap each in foil or plastic. Freeze.

Storage: Freeze up to 3 months · **Reheat:** Microwave 2–3 min from frozen

12 Barbacoa-Style Beef (Dutch Oven)

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 3 lb chuck roast
- 2 chipotle peppers
- 1 tbsp cumin
- 1 tbsp garlic
- 1 onion
- 2 cups beef broth
- 1 tbsp salt

METHOD

1. Season the roast and brown it on all sides, then remove.
2. Cook the onion 5 minutes.
3. Add broth and spices; return the beef.
4. Cover and cook at 325°F for 4 hours.
5. Shred, stir back into the juices, serve.

PART 3

Italian

Simple, few quality ingredients, proper technique. Let the food shine.

1 Restaurant-Style Meat Sauce

Your foundation. Master this first — it feeds spaghetti, baked ziti, lasagna, meatball subs.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs ground beef
- 1 yellow onion, diced
- 6 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 2 cans (28 oz) crushed tomatoes
- 2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp pepper
- 2 tsp Italian seasoning
- 1 tsp sugar

METHOD

1. Heat the Dutch oven over medium with the oil.
2. Cook the onion 5–7 minutes until soft, not browned.
3. Add garlic, cook 30 seconds.
4. Add beef, brown completely, breaking it apart.
5. Add tomatoes, salt, pepper, Italian seasoning and sugar.
6. Simmer at least 45 minutes — 90 is better. Taste and adjust salt.

Storage: 5 days · **Reheat:** Stovetop or microwave

2 Perfect Spaghetti Night

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb spaghetti
- Meat sauce (above)
- Parmesan

METHOD

1. Boil heavily salted water — it should taste slightly salty.
2. Cook spaghetti 8–10 minutes.
3. Reserve 1 cup of pasta water, then drain (don't rinse).
4. Add the spaghetti straight into the sauce, toss, loosen with pasta water if needed, serve.

3 Homemade Meatballs

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs ground beef
- 2 eggs
- 1 cup breadcrumbs
- ½ cup parmesan
- 4 garlic cloves
- 2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp pepper

METHOD

1. Mix everything gently — don't overwork it or they get tough.
2. Form golf-ball-sized meatballs.
3. Bake at 400°F for 20 minutes, to an internal 160°F.
4. Add to sauce and simmer 15 minutes.

4 Garlic Bread

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 loaf bread
- ½ cup softened butter
- 4 garlic cloves
- 2 tbsp parsley
- ½ tsp salt

METHOD

1. Mix the butter, garlic, parsley and salt.
2. Spread on the bread.
3. Bake at 375°F for 10 minutes.
4. Broil 1–2 minutes — watch it closely so it doesn't burn.

5 Chicken Parmesan Bowl

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 chicken breasts
- 1 cup breadcrumbs
- 2 eggs
- 1 cup mozzarella
- 2 cups sauce

METHOD

1. Pound the chicken to even thickness.
2. Egg wash, then coat in breadcrumbs.
3. Bake at 425°F for 20–25 minutes to 165°F.
4. Top with sauce and mozzarella, broil 2 minutes.
5. Serve over pasta.

6 Italian Sausage & Peppers

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 5 Italian sausages
- 2 peppers, sliced
- 1 onion, sliced
- 2 tbsp olive oil

METHOD

1. Cook the sausage over medium 12–15 minutes, then remove.
2. Cook the peppers and onion ~10 minutes.
3. Slice the sausage, return it to the pan, serve.

7 Creamy Garlic Chicken Pasta

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 chicken breasts
- 1 lb pasta
- 4 tbsp butter
- 6 garlic cloves
- 1 cup heavy cream
- ½ cup parmesan

METHOD

1. Cook the pasta, reserving some pasta water.
2. Cook the chicken to 165°F and slice.
3. Melt butter, cook garlic 30 seconds.
4. Add cream, simmer.
5. Whisk in parmesan.
6. Add pasta and chicken, loosen with pasta water, serve.

8 Baked Ziti

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb ziti
- 4 cups sauce
- 2 cups mozzarella
- ½ cup parmesan

METHOD

1. Cook the pasta but undercook by 2 minutes.
2. Mix pasta with sauce, transfer to a baking dish.
3. Top with cheese.
4. Bake at 375°F for 25 minutes.
5. Rest 10 minutes before serving.

9 Dutch Oven Lasagna Pasta

All the flavor of lasagna, half the work.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs ground beef
- 1 onion
- 2 jars marinara
- 12 oz pasta
- 2 cups mozzarella

METHOD

1. Brown the beef, add onion, cook.
2. Add sauce, dry pasta and enough water to cover.
3. Simmer until the pasta is tender.
4. Top with cheese, bake at 375°F for 15 minutes.

10 Homemade Pizza Night

Pizza sauce needs no cooking — just stir it together.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 batch pizza dough (see Bread & Baking)
- Pizza sauce: 1 can crushed tomatoes + 1 tsp salt + 1 tsp garlic powder + 1 tsp oregano
- Mozzarella
- Pepperoni or toppings

METHOD

1. Preheat the oven as hot as it goes (500°F) for 45 minutes — use a steel or stone if you have one.
2. Stretch the dough.
3. Add sauce, then cheese, then toppings.
4. Bake 10–14 minutes until blistered.
5. Rest 3 minutes, slice.

PART 4

Asian

Five building blocks: salt, sweet, acid, aromatics, heat.

1 Teriyaki Chicken Bowls

One of the highest-value meal-prep recipes in the entire book.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

SERVES 5

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs chicken thighs
- 2 cups cooked rice
- 2 cups broccoli
- Sauce: ½ cup soy sauce, ¼ cup water, 2 tbsp honey, 2 tbsp brown sugar, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 2 cloves garlic, 1 tsp grated ginger
- Slurry: 1 tbsp cornstarch + 2 tbsp water

METHOD

1. Cook the rice.
2. Air fry the chicken at 400°F for 20 minutes to 175°F.
3. Simmer all sauce ingredients (not the slurry) 5 minutes.
4. Stir in the slurry, whisk, let it thicken.
5. Slice the chicken, coat in sauce, serve over rice with broccoli.

Storage: 5 days · **Reheat:** Microwave with a splash of water

2 Beef & Broccoli

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 lbs flank steak
- 4 cups broccoli
- Sauce: ½ cup soy sauce, 2 tbsp brown sugar, 2 tsp sesame oil, 3 cloves garlic, 1 tsp ginger

METHOD

1. Freeze the steak 20 minutes, then slice thin against the grain.
2. Cook the broccoli first, then remove.
3. Cook the beef over high heat ~2 minutes.
4. Add sauce, return broccoli, toss, serve.

3 Fried Rice

Cold, day-old rice is the secret. Plan ahead.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 4 cups COLD cooked rice
- 3 eggs
- 1 cup peas and carrots
- 3 green onions
- 3 tbsp soy sauce

METHOD

1. Cold rice only — fresh rice turns to mush.
2. Scramble the eggs, then remove.
3. Cook the vegetables.
4. Add the rice and break it apart.
5. Add soy sauce, then the eggs.
6. Finish with green onions.

4 Garlic Soy Chicken

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs chicken thighs
- ¼ cup soy sauce
- 4 cloves garlic
- 1 tbsp honey

METHOD

1. Marinate 30 minutes.
2. Air fry at 400°F for 20 minutes to 175°F.
3. Serve.

5 Egg Roll Bowl

All the flavor of an egg roll, none of the wrapping.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb ground pork
- 1 bag coleslaw mix
- 3 cloves garlic
- 1 tbsp ginger
- 3 tbsp soy sauce

METHOD

1. Brown the pork.
2. Add garlic and ginger.
3. Add the slaw mix, cook until softened.
4. Add soy sauce, serve.

6 Orange Chicken (Air Fryer)

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs chicken thighs
- 1 cup flour
- 2 eggs
- Sauce: ½ cup orange juice, ¼ cup soy sauce, 2 tbsp honey, 2 garlic cloves, 1 tsp ginger

METHOD

1. Bread the chicken (egg, then flour).
2. Air fry at 400°F for 20 minutes.
3. Simmer the sauce until slightly thick.
4. Toss the chicken in sauce, serve.

7 Sesame Broccoli

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb broccoli
- 1 tbsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp soy sauce

METHOD

1. Roast the broccoli at 425°F for 20 minutes.
2. Finish with soy sauce and sesame oil.

8 Chicken Stir Fry

The 'clean out the fridge' recipe.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs chicken
- 4 cups mixed vegetables
- Sauce: ¼ cup soy sauce, 1 tbsp honey, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 garlic clove

METHOD

1. Cook the chicken, then remove.
2. Cook the vegetables.
3. Add sauce, return chicken, toss, serve.

9 Japanese-Style Steak Rice Bowl

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb sirloin steak
- Cooked rice
- Green onions
- Sauce: 2 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tbsp butter, 1 tsp garlic

METHOD

1. Cook the steak to 130–135°F.
2. Rest, then slice thin.
3. Serve over rice with the sauce and green onions.

10 Korean Ground Beef Bowls

One of the best meal-prep recipes ever — 15 minutes, start to finish.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs ground beef
- ½ cup soy sauce
- 2 tbsp brown sugar
- 3 cloves garlic
- 1 tsp ginger
- Rice
- Green onions

METHOD

1. Brown the beef and drain.
2. Add soy, brown sugar, garlic and ginger.
3. Simmer 5 minutes.
4. Serve over rice with green onions.

11 Chicken Katsu

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Chicken breasts
- Flour
- Eggs
- Panko breadcrumbs

METHOD

1. Bread the chicken: flour, egg, then panko.
2. Air fry at 400°F for 18–20 minutes.
3. Slice and serve.

12 Potsticker Bowl

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Ground pork
- Cabbage
- Garlic
- Ginger
- Soy sauce
- Rice

METHOD

1. Cook the pork.
2. Add the vegetables.
3. Add the sauce.
4. Serve over rice.

PART 5

American Comfort

Tuesday-night food. Reheats well, fills you up, cheap.

1 Ultimate Beef Chili

Your signature meal-prep recipe. Add 1 tbsp cocoa + 1 tsp espresso powder for a 'why is this so good' version.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

SERVES 8–10

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs ground beef
- 1 large onion, diced
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 cans kidney beans
- 2 cans diced tomatoes
- 1 can tomato paste
- 2 cups beef broth
- 2 tbsp chili powder
- 1 tbsp cumin
- 1 tsp paprika
- 2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp pepper

METHOD

1. Brown the beef in the Dutch oven 8–10 minutes, then drain the grease.
2. Add the onion, cook 5 minutes.
3. Add garlic, cook 30 seconds.
4. Add tomatoes, beans, tomato paste, broth and seasonings.
5. Bring to a simmer, reduce heat, and cook 1–2 hours — longer is better.
6. Taste and adjust salt.

Storage: 5 days · freezer 3 months · **Reheat:** Stovetop or microwave

2 Slow Cooked Pot Roast

One of the best Sunday meals — and it makes the apartment smell incredible.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 3 lb chuck roast
- 4 carrots
- 4 potatoes
- 1 onion
- 3 cups beef broth
- 2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp pepper

METHOD

1. Season and brown the roast on all sides, then remove.
2. Cook the onions.
3. Add broth, return the roast, add the vegetables.
4. Cover and cook at 325°F for 4 hours, until it shreds (205°F+).
5. Shred and serve.

3 Air Fryer Chicken Thighs

A cornerstone recipe. The backbone of a hundred meal-prep bowls.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs chicken thighs
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp pepper
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- 1 tsp paprika

METHOD

1. Mix the seasonings and coat the chicken.
2. Air fry at 400°F for 18–22 minutes to 175°F.
3. Rest 5 minutes.

4 Crispy Breakfast Potatoes

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs Yukon potatoes
- 2 tbsp oil
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp garlic powder

METHOD

1. Dice the potatoes.
2. Boil 5 minutes, then drain (this is the trick to crispy).
3. Season.
4. Bake at 425°F for 35 minutes.

5 Egg Sandwich (Master)

This single recipe will save you hundreds of dollars in drive-thru breakfasts.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 eggs
- English muffin
- Cheese
- Butter

METHOD

1. Toast the muffin.
2. Cook the eggs.
3. Add cheese, assemble.

6 Smash Burgers

Learn this and you'll stop buying burgers.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb 80/20 beef
- Burger buns
- American cheese
- Salt
- Pepper

METHOD

1. Make 4 oz balls.
2. Get the skillet very hot.
3. Smash a ball flat, cook 2 minutes.
4. Flip, cook 1 minute, add cheese.
5. Serve.

7 BBQ Pulled Chicken

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs chicken thighs
- 1 cup BBQ sauce

METHOD

1. Slow cooker, LOW 6 hours.
2. Shred, mix with sauce, serve.

8 Sheet Pan Sausage & Vegetables

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 package sausage
- Broccoli
- Potatoes
- Peppers

METHOD

1. Spread everything on a sheet pan.
2. Roast at 425°F for 25 minutes.

9 Loaded Baked Potato Bowls

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Russet potatoes
- Cheese
- Bacon
- Greek yogurt
- Green onions

METHOD

1. Bake the potatoes at 425°F for 60 minutes.
2. Split and top with everything.
3. Serve.

10 Homemade Mac & Cheese

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb pasta
- 4 tbsp butter
- 4 tbsp flour
- 3 cups milk
- 3 cups cheese

METHOD

1. Make a roux: melt butter, whisk in flour.
2. Add milk slowly, whisking.
3. Stir in the cheese until smooth.
4. Fold in the cooked pasta, serve.

11 Chicken & Rice Meal Prep

The bodybuilding classic. Simple, cheap, hits your protein.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Chicken thighs
- Rice
- Broccoli

METHOD

1. Cook all three.
2. Portion into containers.

12 Beef & Potato Skillet

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Ground beef
- Potatoes
- Onion
- Garlic

METHOD

1. Cook the potatoes first.
2. Add the beef, then the onion.
3. Season and serve.

13 Chicken Noodle Soup

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Chicken thighs
- Carrots
- Celery
- Onion
- Egg noodles
- Chicken broth

METHOD

1. Cook the vegetables.
2. Add the broth and chicken.
3. Simmer.
4. Add the noodles last so they don't go mushy.

14 Dutch Oven Beef Stew

Cold-weather champion.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Chuck roast
- Potatoes
- Carrots
- Beef broth
- Tomato paste

METHOD

1. Brown the meat.
2. Add vegetables and broth.
3. Bake at 325°F for 3 hours.

15 Homemade Meatloaf

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lbs ground beef
- 2 eggs
- Breadcrumbs
- Onion
- Ketchup

METHOD

1. Mix everything.
2. Form a loaf.
3. Bake at 350°F for 60 minutes to 160°F.

PART 6

High Protein & San Diego

Food you love, made to hit your protein. Plus the local classics.

1 High Protein Breakfast Burritos

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

PROTEIN 40–50g

INGREDIENTS

- 12 eggs
- 1 lb turkey sausage
- 1 cup low-fat cheese
- 8 tortillas

METHOD

1. Cook the turkey sausage.
2. Scramble the eggs.
3. Combine, fill the tortillas, wrap and freeze.

2 Steak & Sweet Potato Bowls

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

PROTEIN 50g+

INGREDIENTS

- 8 oz sirloin
- 1 sweet potato
- Broccoli

METHOD

1. Cook the steak to 130–135°F, rest, slice.
2. Roast the sweet potato and broccoli.
3. Assemble the bowl.

3 Air Fryer Salmon

One of the healthiest, fastest recipes in the book.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

PROTEIN 45g+

INGREDIENTS

- Salmon
- Olive oil
- Salt
- Pepper
- Garlic

METHOD

1. Coat the salmon in oil and seasoning.
2. Air fry at 400°F for 8–10 minutes to 125–130°F internal.

4 Greek Chicken Bowls

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

PROTEIN 45g+

INGREDIENTS

- Chicken
- Cucumber
- Tomato
- Rice
- Tzatziki

METHOD

1. Cook the chicken.
2. Build the bowl with rice, chopped cucumber and tomato.
3. Top with tzatziki.

5 Buffalo Chicken Bowls

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

PROTEIN 45g+

INGREDIENTS

- Chicken
- Rice
- Broccoli
- Buffalo sauce
- Greek yogurt ranch

METHOD

1. Cook the chicken and toss in buffalo sauce.
2. Build the bowl with rice and broccoli.
3. Drizzle with Greek yogurt ranch.

6 White Chicken Chili

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

PROTEIN 40g+

INGREDIENTS

- Chicken thighs
- White beans
- Chicken broth
- Green chiles

METHOD

1. Combine everything in a pot.
2. Simmer 1 hour.
3. Shred the chicken back in, serve.

7 Protein French Toast

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

PROTEIN 35g+

INGREDIENTS

- Bread
- Eggs
- Protein powder
- Cinnamon
- Milk

METHOD

1. Whisk eggs, protein powder, cinnamon and milk.
2. Dip the bread.
3. Cook on a buttered skillet over medium until golden both sides.

8 California Burrito

The San Diego icon. Skip the tortilla and bowl it for the lighter version.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Carne asada
- French fries (air fryer)
- Cheese
- Large tortilla

METHOD

1. Make the carne asada and fries.
2. Pile carne asada, fries and cheese on the tortilla.
3. Roll tight and serve.

9 Carne Asada Fries

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Air fryer fries
- Carne asada
- Cheese
- Guacamole
- Pico

METHOD

1. Make the fries and carne asada.
2. Layer fries, cheese (melt it), carne asada.
3. Top with guacamole and pico.

10 Fish Tacos

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- White fish
- Corn tortillas
- Cabbage
- Lime crema (Greek yogurt + lime + salt)

METHOD

1. Season and pan-cook or air-fry the fish.
2. Warm the tortillas.
3. Build with cabbage, fish and lime crema.

11 Fish Taco Bowls

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- White fish
- Cabbage
- Lime
- Pico
- Chipotle sauce
- Rice

METHOD

1. Cook the fish.
2. Build the bowl with rice, cabbage, pico.
3. Top with chipotle sauce and a squeeze of lime.

12 Rolled Tacos (Taquitos)

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Shredded beef
- Corn tortillas
- Cheese
- Lettuce

METHOD

1. Fill tortillas with shredded beef, roll tight.
2. Air fry or pan-fry until crisp.
3. Top with cheese and lettuce.

PART 7

Bread & Baking

Stop buying dough and bread. This is cooking from scratch.

1 Master Pizza Dough

The recipe to memorize. Freezes great — make 4 batches and thaw 24 hrs in the fridge for pizza anytime.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 500g bread flour
- 350g warm water
- 10g salt
- 3g instant yeast
- 10g olive oil

METHOD

1. Combine water and yeast, wait 5 minutes.
2. Add flour, salt and oil.
3. Knead in the KitchenAid on speed 2 for 8 minutes (or 8 min by hand).
4. Move to an oiled bowl, cover, rise 1–2 hours until doubled.
5. Divide into 2 balls, rest 30 minutes.
6. Stretch, top and bake. Preheat the oven 500°F for 45 minutes; use a steel if you have one.

2 Dutch Oven No-Knead Bread

The recipe that makes you realize: I can actually make bread.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 500g flour
- 375g water
- 10g salt
- 3g yeast

METHOD

1. Mix to a shaggy dough.
2. Cover and rise overnight, 12–18 hours.
3. Preheat the Dutch oven at 450°F.
4. Bake covered 30 minutes, then uncovered 15 minutes.
5. Cool completely before slicing.

3 Dutch Oven Sandwich Bread

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 500g bread flour
- 325g water
- 10g salt
- 7g yeast
- 20g honey
- 20g olive oil

METHOD

1. Mix, then knead 8 minutes.
2. Rise 1 hour.
3. Shape into a loaf, rise 45 minutes.
4. Bake at 375°F for 35 minutes to an internal 200°F.

4 Hamburger Buns

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 500g flour
- 300g milk
- 50g butter
- 1 egg
- 10g salt
- 7g yeast
- 25g sugar

METHOD

1. Mix and knead to a smooth dough.
2. Rise until doubled.
3. Shape into buns, rise again.
4. Bake at 375°F for 15–18 minutes.

5 Dinner Rolls

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 500g flour
- 300g milk
- 50g butter
- 50g sugar
- 1 egg
- 7g yeast

METHOD

1. Mix and knead.
2. Rise until doubled.
3. Shape into rolls, rise again.
4. Bake at 375°F for 15 minutes.

6 Buttermilk Biscuits

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups flour
- 1 tbsp baking powder
- 1 tsp salt
- 6 tbsp COLD butter
- ¾ cup buttermilk

METHOD

1. Mix the dry ingredients.
2. Cut in the cold butter (cold is the whole game).
3. Add buttermilk, fold gently.
4. Cut biscuits, bake at 425°F for 12–15 minutes.

7 Brownies

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup butter
- 2 cups sugar
- 4 eggs
- 1 cup cocoa powder
- 1 cup flour

METHOD

1. Mix everything.
2. Pour into a pan.
3. Bake at 350°F for 30 minutes.
4. Cool, then slice.

PART 8

Hosting & Special Occasion

The recipes people remember. Master them first, then serve them.

1 Reverse Seared Ribeye

The steak recipe. Impressiveness: 5/5. Serve with Caesar salad and Dutch oven bread.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 2 ribeyes
- Kosher salt
- Black pepper
- Avocado oil
- Butter
- Garlic
- Rosemary

METHOD

1. Salt the steaks and leave them uncovered in the fridge 12–24 hours.
2. Bake at 250°F until they hit 115°F internal (about 30–45 minutes).
3. Heat the skillet very hot with avocado oil.
4. Sear 60 seconds per side.
5. Add butter, garlic and rosemary; baste.
6. Pull at 130–135°F, rest 10 minutes.

2 Braised Short Ribs

Special-occasion food.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 4 lbs short ribs
- Red wine
- Beef broth
- Carrots
- Onion
- Garlic

METHOD

1. Brown the ribs on all sides.
2. Cook the vegetables.
3. Add wine and reduce.
4. Add broth, return the ribs.
5. Bake at 325°F for 3.5 hours.
6. Serve over mashed potatoes.

3 Restaurant-Style Caesar Salad

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Dressing: ½ cup mayo, 2 tbsp lemon juice, 1 garlic clove, 2 tbsp parmesan, anchovy optional
- Romaine
- Croutons
- Parmesan

METHOD

1. Whisk the dressing ingredients.
2. Toss with chopped romaine.
3. Top with croutons and parmesan.

4 Holiday Mashed Potatoes

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- 5 lbs Yukon potatoes
- 1 stick butter
- 1 cup WARM milk
- Salt

METHOD

1. Boil the potatoes until fork-tender.
2. Mash with butter.
3. Add warm milk gradually — cold milk ruins the texture.
4. Salt to taste.

5 Smoked-Style Pulled Pork (Dutch Oven)

For people without a smoker — your Dutch oven gets you most of the way.

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

INGREDIENTS

- Pork shoulder
- Dry rub (salt, pepper, paprika, garlic, brown sugar)
- Splash of broth

METHOD

1. Coat the pork in the rub.
2. Brown it, add a splash of broth.
3. Cover and cook at 275°F for 6–8 hours until it shreds.
4. Shred and serve.

6 Carne Asada Party Pack

DIFFICULTY ●●●●●

COST \$\$\$\$

MEAL PREP ■■■■■

REHEAT ■■■■■

SERVES 10+

INGREDIENTS

- 5 lbs carne asada (scale the marinade x2.5)
- Large batch rice
- Large batch pico
- Large batch guacamole
- Tortillas

METHOD

1. Marinate the steak overnight.
2. Cook in batches so the pan stays hot.
3. Set everything out as a build-your-own taco bar.

REFERENCE

Sauces, Lists & Systems

The quick-flip pages you'll come back to constantly.

Sauces, Salsas & Dressings — Mix & Store

SAUCE	BUILD
Stir Fry	¼ cup soy, 1 tbsp honey, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 garlic clove
Teriyaki	½ cup soy, 2 tbsp honey, 2 tbsp brown sugar, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 tsp garlic, 1 tsp ginger — simmer & thicken
Yum Yum	½ cup mayo, 1 tbsp ketchup, 1 tsp garlic powder
Spicy Mayo	½ cup mayo, 1 tbsp sriracha
Burger Sauce	½ cup mayo, 2 tbsp ketchup, 1 tbsp mustard, 1 tbsp pickle juice, 1 tsp garlic powder
Chipotle Sauce	½ cup mayo, 2 chipotle peppers, 1 lime, 1 garlic clove — blend
Garlic Aioli	½ cup mayo, 2 garlic cloves, 1 tsp lemon juice
Greek Yogurt Ranch	½ cup mayo, ½ cup Greek yogurt, 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 tsp onion powder, 1 tbsp dill
Vinaigrette	3 tbsp olive oil, 1 tbsp vinegar, salt, pepper

Core Marinades

Carne Asada: ½ cup orange juice, 2 limes, ¼ cup olive oil, 4 garlic cloves, 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp chili powder, 1 tsp salt. Marinate 4–24 hrs.

Chicken Taco: 2 tbsp olive oil, juice of 1 lime, 1 tsp each cumin, chili powder, garlic powder, salt. Marinate 1–12 hrs.

The Gio Meal-Prep Formula — 400 Combinations

Every Sunday, pick one from each column. That's $5 \times 4 \times 4 \times 5 = 400$ meals without repeating.

PROTEIN	VEGETABLE	CARB	SAUCE
Chicken thighs	Broccoli	Rice	Chipotle
Carne asada	Brussels sprouts	Potatoes	Salsa roja
Chili	Green beans	Sweet potatoes	Teriyaki
Ground beef	Mixed vegetables	Pasta	Ranch
Salmon			Garlic aioli

Plate method: 50% protein, 25% vegetables, 25% carbs. Protein goal ~200–250g/day — consistent beats perfect.

The Roadmap — Master in Order

Level 1: Scrambled eggs · rice · roasted broccoli · chicken thighs · ground beef

Level 2: Chili · spaghetti · chicken taco bowls · teriyaki chicken · fried rice

Level 3: Carne asada · pot roast · pizza dough · Dutch oven bread · meatballs

Level 4: Homemade pizza · sandwich bread · biscuits · brownies · cakes

Gio's Top 10 Lifetime Recipes

If you only kept ten: **1.** Carne Asada **2.** Chili **3.** Chicken Thighs **4.** Chicken Taco Bowls **5.** Pizza Dough **6.** Homemade Pizza **7.** Dutch Oven Bread **8.** Pot Roast **9.** Teriyaki Chicken **10.** Fish Taco Bowls

The Most Important Lesson

The goal is not to become a chef. The goal is to become the kind of man who can feed himself, feed his family, feed his friends, take care of his health, and enjoy the process.

If you can do that, you've won.